

The Database of Religious History Repository Analysis

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The repository I chose to analyze is the Database of Religious History. The database describes itself as a centralized hub for scholarly knowledge on religions and their history across regions worldwide and throughout time. It serves as a tool for tracking the evolutions of religions both quantitatively and qualitatively to locate patterns and trends through a database that operates much like an encyclopedia (DRH, 2025).

While the repository describes itself as a database that hosts scholarly information in a way that builds on itself to track topics across time, it does not clarify whether the repository considers itself archival. So, while the website never clarifies how it sees itself regarding its active participation in managing records throughout their different stages of life, through their description of what they do and how they do it, the DRH does seem to be following the OAIS Reference Model. The OAIS Reference Model is defined as “an archive, consisting of an organization of people and systems that has accepted the responsibility to preserve information and make it available for a Designated Community” (Oliver & Harvey, 2016, pp. 38). The DRH follows all of the OAIS Reference Model’s actions of submission, ingest, archival storage, data management, preservation planning, administration and access (Oliver & Harvey, 2016).

Repository Ownership

The database is the initiative of the Cultural Evolution of Religion Research Consortium (CERC), created and based at the University of British Columbia in Vancouver. It now operates as an independent academic initiative involving partners and collaborators from all over the world, but is still based at UBC (DRH, 2025). It seems that the Cultural Evolution of Religion Research Consortium manages the long-term holdings internally through the staff involved. There is a good-sized staff listed and the staff directory shows that there is a technical director and data scientist on the team. The website also mentions that they partner with Pieoneers Software Inc., which is a web development studio that manages the website framework (DRH, 2025).

Receiving and Selecting Materials

As Ryan and Walker state “having clearly defined policies and procedures in place before born-digital content is brought into your institution can ensure that only the material that fits the mission statement of the institution is acquired, stored, and maintained” (2018, pp. 40). Users can contribute to the database by signing up for an account and submitting an entry containing their scholarly work and findings. This is done by downloading what are referred to as polls that serve as questionnaires to be filled in by the

religion expert to be published in the database. These polls are downloaded and submitted as PDFs (DRH, 2025).

The repository has a kind of documented selection strategy on the website per say. The database is open-access and the information within the repository is sourced by experts submitting their entries, so there seems to be less of a selection strategy for the records within the repository itself, but more of a selection strategy for the people that are allowed to submit. The policy on their website does state the requirements for which fields they are looking for scholars from and what level of education the experts are to have to be considered for the acceptance of their entry contributions. There is also an approval process in place where editors, who are experts in certain regions of the world, need to approve of the entry before it can be published (DRH, 2025).

The system in place for submitting entries as a creator, also referred to as an expert on the website, is also very rigid in structure and I imagine does some of the work of establishing a strategy for selection to ensure that there is a certain level of consistency with the types of information that are present within each entry. The downloadable polls essentially operate as fill in the blank questionnaires with very specific topics of information to be provided by the expert (e.g. questions on religious group interactions, gender roles, the afterlife, etc.). The very rigid structure of having pre-selected questions that need to be answered to ensure consistency of the types of information provided does serve as a sort of selection strategy for deciding what types of information are being gathered by the repository (DRH, 2025).

Membership/Group Interactions

Are other religious groups in cultural contact with target religion:

— Yes / No / Field doesn't know / I don't know

Comments / Sources:

→ If Yes:

Is the cultural contact competitive:

— Yes / No / Field doesn't know / I don't know

Comments / Sources:

Is the cultural contact accommodating/pluralistic:

— Yes / No / Field doesn't know / I don't know

Comments / Sources:

Is the cultural contact neutral:

— Yes / No / Field doesn't know / I don't know

Comments / Sources:

Is there violent conflict (within sample region):

— Yes / No / Field doesn't know / I don't know

Comments / Sources:

Is there violent conflict (with groups outside the sample region):

— Yes / No / Field doesn't know / I don't know

Comments / Sources:

Because the repository collection is solely limited to collecting information based on the structures of the polls, it appears to closely follow the collection strategy for ingesting information. The information present for each entry listed on the database is consistent across the board by topic since topics have content and question specific polls that experts fill out and upload for approval. As for the actual selection strategy for reviewing and selecting which entries make it into the repository, that is a bit more of a gray area. Not much information is provided for what exactly the editors are using or looking for to select which entries make it into the repository. I'm not sure if there are industry

standards that the editors refer to or if it is based solely on their expertise, meaning that there is room for inconsistency in the selection strategy by area of expertise.

This strict adherence to relying on the polls to populate data within the database means that the scope of the repository very closely aligns with its selection strategy. The entire scope of the repository consists of information about religious groups, religious places, religious text, religious rituals, and polity because those are the only types of polls available to populate (DRH, 2025)

RELIGIOUS GROUP	RELIGIOUS PLACE	RELIGIOUS TEXT	RELIGIOUS RITUAL	POLITY	EXTERNAL
Poll name	Date modified	Entries	PDF		
Gratitude Experiences and expressions of gratitude towards supernatural agents, humans, and other beings	May 19, 2025	46	Download		
Agents of Mystical Harm (v1.1) The Agents of Mystical Harm (SOMH) is a newly-created dataset, designed to characterize patterns in beliefs about practitioners of mystical harm across societies. Each entry refers to a different practitioner of mystical harm. Some societies will have several of such practitioners – for example, an ethnographer might describe one kind	Jan 24, 2023	10	Download		

Audience

The repository clearly indicates who it intends for its audience to be. “For scholars, researchers, teachers and the general public, the DRH functions as a gateway to reliable, comprehensive knowledge concerning the history of religions around the world, and cultural history more generally” (DRH, 2025). It also includes an entire webpage for the pedagogical uses of the material it contains. It provides extensive background information for the ways that the database can support lessons as a teaching platform for both the undergraduate and graduate levels. The repository has even provided lesson plans and instruction guides that can be downloaded and used for instruction in the classroom (DRH, 2025).

It’s easy to see how the nature of the objects and the descriptive material provided fit the needs of the community. The database advertises itself a central location for scholars to both host and find historical religious record to track the evolution of religions across time. Because the intended use is for research, each entry provides the relevant information a researcher might need for studying religions like, the name of the religious group, the area they’re located, the date ranges for the religion, as well as information on beliefs, practices and social structures that the person that created the entry provided on

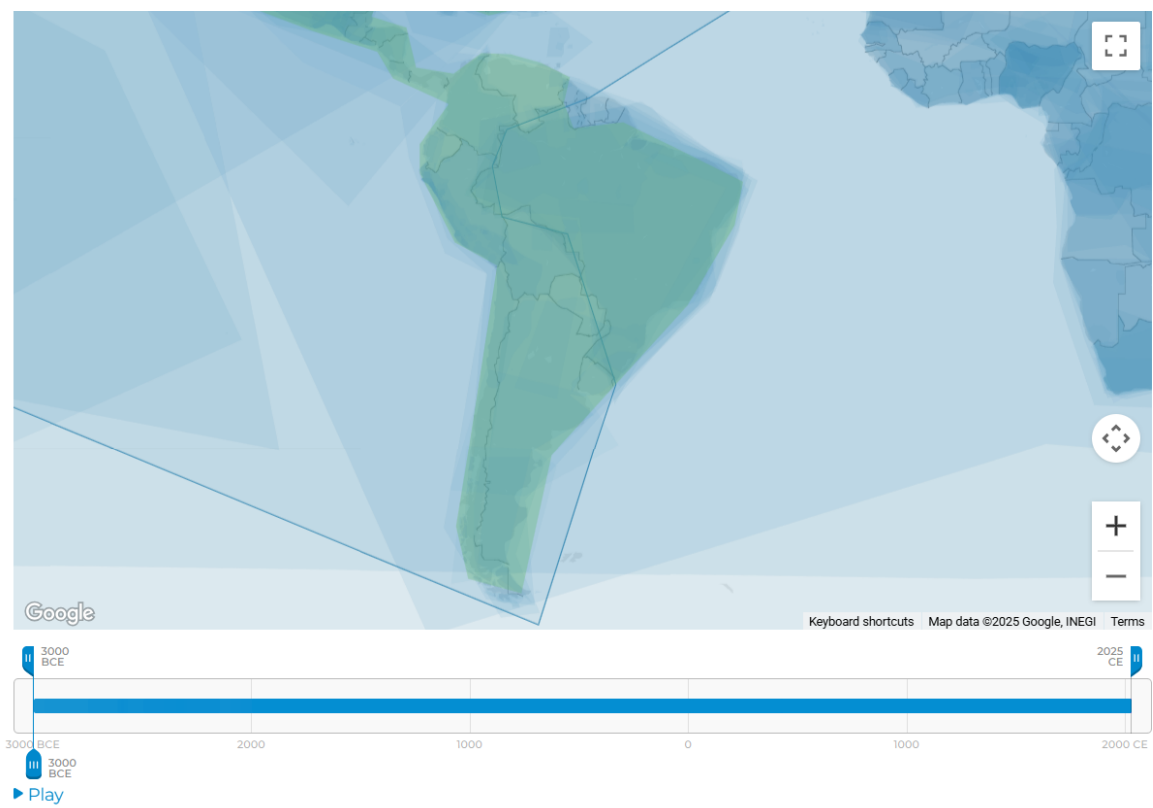
the entry poll. Each entry also contains sections where the creator has linked their sources as well as relevant contextual media and files. Entries also contain tags that link the scholar out to other related entries hosted by the repository to build out their contextual knowledge (DRH, 2025).

Lessons Plans and Instructor Guides

Thanks to a grant from UBC's [Open Education Research Fund](#) we were able to create a set of lesson plans and instructor guides ready to be used in the classroom. They are designed to be flexible enough for a variety of subject areas, but all of them include some aspect of digital literacy. Furthermore, they can be used in sequence or individually, each instructor guide makes clear what prerequisites are required.

1. **An Introduction to Databases and the Database of Religious History**
 - [Download lesson plan](#)
 - [Download instructor's guide](#)
2. **Browsing the Database of Religious History**
 - [Download lesson plan](#)
 - [Download instructor's guide](#)
3. **Visualizing Data and the Database of Religious History**
 - [Download lesson plan](#)
 - [Download instructor's guide](#)
4. **Digital Tools and the Study of the History of Religions**
 - [Download lesson plan](#)
 - [Download instructor's guide](#)
5. **Thinking Critically About Expert Knowledge**
 - [Download lesson plan](#)
 - [Download instructor's guide](#)

The commitment to scholarly research is also shown through the database’s built in analytic and data visualization tools that allows for researchers to approach the material in new and innovative ways allowing for the connection, comparison and analysis of information between different religions, regions, and across historical timeframes (DRH, 2025).



Entries using "Latin America" region:

Entry title	Expert	Published on	Poll	Date range
Christian Base Community movement	Brendan Jordan	Jul 29, 2020	Religious Group (v6)	1968 CE – 1998 CE

Analyze

Download DRH data

The DRH has created a full data dump, frozen on June 27, 2024, in the form of the Standard Cross-Cultural Sample of Religion (SCCSR), v1. A second version, v2, was frozen on February 25, 2025. Accompanying documentation explains the nature of the sample, suggestions for correcting for DRH over- and under-sampling in various regions, and some suggested coding transformations.

DOWNLOAD SCCSR.V1

[Read SCCSR Documentation](#)

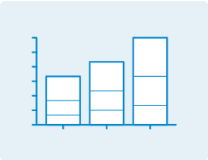
DOWNLOAD SCCSR.V2

The data is provided under a CC-BY-4.0 license.

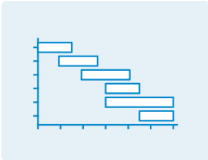
Analyze on the DRH site

If you would like to analyze DRH using tools built into the site, please begin by selecting a graph type below, and following the prompts to provide the data you wish to be analyzed.

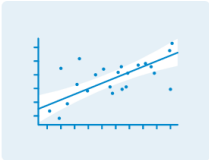
Select graph type:



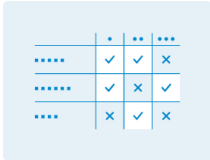
Bar Chart



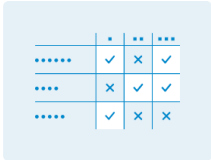
Timeline



Scatter Plot



Question Answers Comparison



Entry Answers Comparison

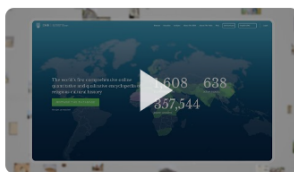
User Guides

The repository provides a plethora of user guides and tutorials explaining multiple aspects of the repository. These guides come in the format of short videos and provide users with tutorials ranging from explanations of the goals of the database itself to overviews of the features of the website and how to use and contribute to it. The videos providing information on how to use the website walks users through browsing the content, using the visualization function, and the built-in tools to analyze the data making the repository feel approachable and easy to access and use (DRH, 2025).



Exploring Religion's Past, Present, and Future

An introduction to the goals and purpose of the DRH, and its potential for new forms of scholarly research.



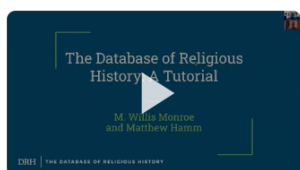
Getting Started with the Database of Religious History

A tutorial on how to browse, visualize, analyze, and contribute data in the DRH.



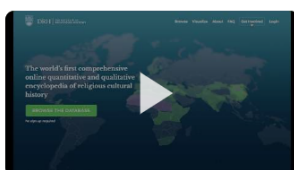
DRH Overview

A brief overview of the DRH.



DRH Tutorial

An introduction to the DRH and an overview of the major features of the website.



Overview of the Database of Religious History

A tour of the DRH, including sign up, entry creation, Browse our data, and visualizing the results.

Database of Religious History Staff

The database has a sizeable staff that covers the variety of roles needed to run a database that focuses on religion. Because the repository runs as an independent entity, it requires the staff to cover the needs of the scholarly side, as well as employees to cover the more technical side of running a database. The staff consists of project directors, a technical director, a chief data scientist, a primary scientific advisor, the steering committee, an advisory board, expert consultants, and Postdocs. To manage the arm of the database that deals with the review of entries submitted by researchers and religious experts, the DRH also has a team of editors to review submitted polls. The team of editors is arranged by global region of expertise. Because it is a scholarly database all members of the staff have the listed credentials to show that they are also academics and experts in their respective fields. The staff, both the management team and editors, are comprised of a mix of researchers or professors at universities around the world. The repository provides a directory which includes the name of the staff, their role with the database, as well as which university they are affiliated with and what their specialty is (DRH, 2025). The ability to easily click through each staff members' profile and review their qualifications establishes a level of trust amongst users of this database to know that while the information collected is being submitted by outside users of the community, there is both a system and the professionals in place to ensure that information being submitted for publication meets scholarly standards.



Rohini Shukla

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INSTITUTION
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DEPARTMENT
Middle Eastern, South Asian, and African Studies Department

AREA OF RESEARCH
South Asian Religions, Bhakti, Marathi Literature, Gender and Caste, Hinduism

POSITION
Adjunct Professor

LOCATION
New York

ROLE AT DRH
Expert, Regional Editor (South Asia)

Research Interests

- Religion
- South Asia
- History Of Religion
- Bhakti
- Maharashtra

Database Contributions

Entry name	Progress	Published	Date modified
Bahinabai Chaudhari's Songs: A Performance Tradition in Maharashtra	100% Total: 85/85	Mar 26 2023 All answered questions are published	Mar 26, 2023

If I had relevant data to deposit, I would feel comfortable using this repository because of the structure that exists. The system in place acts much like a scholarly journal where the information being submitted must be vetted and peer reviewed by other professionals in the industry before it is accepted for publication. The repository essentially provides general overviews of religions around the world throughout time but links outwardly to existing scholarly sources to back up their research claims. It's like a Wikipedia for religions if all the submissions were peer reviewed and only those with the expertise and credentials to back it up were allowed to submit.

Authenticity

The repository also contains a directory of the scholarly experts who currently have published entries on the database. The directory is clickable and allows users to access a

submitters profile which includes information on the institution they're located at, their area of research, and their position at said institution. The database also tracks and links to the entries that the expert has contributed. The contribution tracker shows the entry name, the progress level in terms of completeness of entry, the date the entry was published as well as the last date of modification DRH, 2025). The fact that the database is tracking this information for each entry helps ensure the integrity and authenticity of the record (Ohio State University, 2025).

Database Contributions

Entry name	Progress	Published	Date modified
Religion in Nabataea	 95% Total: 178/188 38/43	Aug 17 2022 1 new question answered but not published	May 28, 2022
Petra Great Temple	 95% Total: 174/183	Aug 29 2022 All answered questions are published	Aug 18, 2022
Khazneh (Petra)	 91% Total: 149/164	Aug 18 2022 All answered questions are published	Aug 18, 2022

The inclusion of descriptive metadata also works to assure the authenticity of the records through the information on content, context, structure, and provenance that it provides (Oliver & Harvey, 2016). Each entry provides the entry name, the creator, a description, keywords submitted as tags, the publication date, a corresponding Doi, as well as the archived PDF that was initially submitted to populate the webpage. Database users also have access to the cited sources used to create the entry, so researchers easily have the ability to check that the scholarly work is factual (DRH, 2025).

 **Religion in Nabataea** by Anna Accettola

[Cite entry](#) [View sources](#) [Print View](#)

Religious Group Ancient Mediterranean Tomb Arabian Religions Petra Nabataea Afro-Asiatic Semitic and 8 more

Religion in Nabataea was a confluence of native and foreign deities and practices which spread across the Arabian desert. Ranging from the worship of beyl blocks to figural sculpture, sacred high places to Greco-Roman temples, priestly worship in sacred places to traveling... [Read more](#)



Map Satellite

Date Range: 300 BCE - 450 CE

Region: Kingdom of Nabataea

Israel Arabian Peninsula Levant Judean Desert Egypt Saudi Arabia Jordan Egyptian Desert

Extent of settlements of the Nabataean Kingdom during height of its power from 1st century BCE to 1st century CE

Search questions and answers...

215 question answered Last update on Jan 5 2023

 **Status of Participants:**
☒ Elite ☒ Religious Specialists ☒ Non-elite (common people, general populace)

> Contextual media/files

Cite this entry:



This entry was updated after the current DOI was issued. Please note that the citation below pertains to the archived version the DOI was issued for, and not the live version on the DRH website.

DOI	Issued on	Archived PDF
10.5281/zenodo.12573460 Current	Jun 27 2024	View

Citation Style: [APA \(5th Edition\)](#) ▼

Anna Accettola. (2022, June 04). Religion in Nabataea. Database of Religious History, Vancouver, BC: University of British Columbia. Retrieved June 27, 2024, from <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.12573460>



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Trustworthiness

When it comes to digital repositories trust is a vital element. As Prieto states, “while digital repositories may be trustworthy because of adherence to technological standards, accepted practices, and mechanisms for authenticating the authorship and accuracy of their content, it is ultimately their respective stakeholder - both those who deposit and use content – whose perceptions play a central role in ensuring a digital repository’s trustworthiness” (2009, 593). It is the subtle way that the repository provides and structures the information in an easily accessible way that makes the database

instinctively feel trustworthy. This includes but is not limited to the clear and open messaging up front and center for users to access about what the process looks like for getting entries accepted, the ability to access the metadata and cited sources very clearly and easily for each individual entry, and the ability to view the staff, editor, and expert profiles to see where they work, what their profession is, and what their expertise are.

Conclusion

The analysis of the Database of Religious History very closely aligns with the themes prevalent in the course. The database is a great example of how the OAIS Reference Model can be followed to structure and manage a digital repository where the data within it is submitted by the community. The analysis also highlighted the ways in which policy helps structure and set the parameters for the scope of the repository and informs users about what the database accepts and therefore what it serves to accomplish. All of this messaging, along with the ways in which the data and metadata within the database are structured and archived work towards showing potential users that the repository is trustworthy and therefore useful for reference for scholarly work.

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